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ENC 2135

Reflective Statement

I came into this course one year from graduating, which made this class matter more than I expected it to. As a CS student who plans for grad school, I wanted to sharpen the writing skills I'll actually use in the future; research papers, technical communication, and the kind of persuasive writing that has to land with people who don't share your background. The summer term moved fast. But, I think the speed benefitted me because it forced me to work on the clock like a real job.

The skill I gained this semester is audience awareness. The course framed it through discourse communities and the rhetorical triangle, and at first that felt like vocabulary I already had. I had written for general readers before. I had written for technical readers before. What I had not done was write about the same topic for three different audiences in the same project. Project 2 made that obvious in a way no reading assignment could have. This was quite a challenge for me at first.

The project was a persuasive campaign arguing that quantum computing is a near-term threat to RSA encryption, not the decades-away curiosity most people still treat it as. I wrote three pieces: a blog post for informed but non-technical readers, an Instagram carousel on the @uncover.quantum account for Gen Z social media users, and an infographic/timeline for professionals who needed quick visual reference. The research was identical across all three. The rhetorical strategy was not. The blog leaned on logos because the readers had time to follow a real argument with sources. The carousel had to lead with pathos and curiosity because nobody scrolling on Instagram wants to read a paragraph. The infographic was almost pure ethos, built

around credibility signals like IBM and NIST and Google Quantum AI so a busy professional could trust the numbers without reading the source list. I had used ethos, pathos, and logos as terms in high school, but until I had to weigh them differently across three deliverables in one project, I saw a new value.

The clearest revision moment of the semester came during a 1-on-1 with my professor on the blog post. The draft was technically fine. The argument held together; the sources were there; the writing was clean. Yet, he flagged the title. My title did not tell a reader what the blog was actually about. His point was that the title is the first rhetorical move you make, and if it does not work, the rest of the piece is confusing. We talked through what a blog reader needs in the first three seconds: the topic, the stakes, and a reason to keep going. I revised the title to something direct. It said quantum is not decades away, and it said, “and this is why that matters.” I had spent so much energy on the body of the blog that I had forgotten how key the title is. So, this was a key reminder at age 21, that the audience's first encounter with your argument is your title, and if you whiff it the rest of your work pays the price.

There was a smaller revision moment that reinforced the same idea from a different angle. My dad read an early draft of the blog and told me my bold claims needed more evidence. Once I went back and pinned specific numbers and named sources to the strong claims, the blog post got firmer. That was a lesson about the balance between pathos and logos. You cannot substitute one for the other. Confidence reads as posturing if there is no evidence/logos to back it up.

Where I expect this to apply next is everywhere. Grad school applications will need me to write about quantum computing for a faculty audience that knows the field cold, then turn around and write about the same research for a fellowship committee that does not. I think that to be a

valuable and rounded Employee, being able to deliver information in different forms is very key. This also deeply relates to the skills of being given a large amount of data and having to select, combine, or shorten data from your sources to fit different skills. I specifically worked on this a lot in Project 2 because I had a ton of information, yet writing a 300-word Instagram post is very different than a 1000+ word blog. So again, from this class I learned how to select and cater the information I have gathered to specific audiences, always asking myself, “what emotional appeal am I targeting here?” If I keep building products on the entrepreneurial side, every pitch deck and landing page is the same audience problem in different clothes. Technical communication at internships demands the same thing, I have seen it when I worked for Cisco Systems last summer. Overall, this course forced me to make deliberate choices about the audience instead of defaulting to whatever voice I happened to be in. That is the part I am taking with me the most but overall, I really did enjoy sharpening my writing skills on a tight timeline because it gave me skills and practice for what it might look like in a research lab as a Graduate Student in the future.